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Faculty of Economics
University of Cambridge
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Placement Officers	Prof. Constantine Yannelis	cny21@cam.ac.uk
	Prof. Matthew Elliott	mle30@cam.ac.uk
Placement Coordinator	Louise Cross	JobMarket@econ.cam.ac.uk

EDUCATION

PhD in Economics, *University of Cambridge* *2021 - Present*

Main advisor: Tiago Cavalcanti
Primary Fields: Macro-Development & Environmental Economics
Research visits: FGV São Paulo (2024/25), Oxford (January 2023)

Master of Philosophy in Economics, *University of Oxford* *2018 - 2020*

Master of Science in Economics, *Royal Holloway, University of London* *2016 - 2017*

MSc Student Prize for best graduate at the Department of Economics

Bachelor of Science in Economics, *Humboldt-Universität zu Berlin* *2012 - 2016*

REFERENCES

Prof. Tiago Cavalcanti
University of Cambridge
tvdvc2@cam.ac.uk

Prof. Vasco M. Carvalho
University of Cambridge
vmcarvalho.web@gmail.com

Prof. Christopher Rauh
IAE-CSIC and
Barcelona School of Economics
cr542@cam.ac.uk

JOB MARKET PAPER

Deforestation without Development? Trade, Land Use, and Technology Investments

with Fernando Chertman

Abstract. Does higher foreign demand for agricultural exports drive economic development through technology adoption, or simply fuel deforestation through land expansion? We study this question during Brazil's 2000s commodity boom, combining novel data on the near-universe of agricultural input purchases from cross-bank transactions with satellite data on farm-level land use. Using a shift-share shock, we find that a proportional increase in foreign demand for beef and soy causes farmers in the Amazon to reallocate land from capital-intensive soybean toward land-intensive pasture, reducing their purchases of machinery and technology as pasture replaces forest. We show that this response emerges as a privately optimal decision due to the asymmetric use of land and technology across agricultural activities: abundant land can cause farmers to specialize in pasture, reducing the area under crop cultivation needed to justify technology investments. We then embed this mechanism in general equilibrium and find that deforestation accounted for almost half of agricultural value added growth, compared with less than 10% from technology. Lastly, we provide a welfare rationale for forest protection beyond environmental externalities, arising instead from incentivizing labor-saving modernization which reduces labor misallocation. A perfectly enforced no-deforestation tax of around US$700 per hectare redirects growth toward technology adoption and raises the welfare gains from trade by more than 75 percent.

WORKING PAPERS

Differential Land Efficiency and the Environmental Consequences of Agricultural Productivity Growth

with Tiago Cavalcanti
Revise & Resubmit, Journal of Development Economics

CEPR Discussion Paper · STEG Working Paper

Abstract. Does improving agricultural productivity spare forests or accelerate their demise? We offer a new perspective on this debate by emphasizing the relative agricultural suitability of forest versus available vacant land for conversion. We develop a parsimonious framework in which land differs in agricultural efficiency across alternative expansion margins, showing that productivity gains translate into deforestation only when forests constitute the most cost-effective source of additional effective land. We test this prediction using a quasi-experimental design based on Tanzania's National Agricultural Input Voucher Scheme (NAIVS), which promoted modern seed and fertilizer adoption. Combining high-resolution satellite data on forest loss with spatial data on soil nitrogen to proxy relative suitability, we find that the program increased deforestation only in villages where vacant land was substantially less productive than forest land. Our results highlight the central role of land quality heterogeneity in shaping the environmental consequences of agricultural productivity growth, offer a complementary explanation for land-sparing versus expansionary outcomes, and point to a role for directed agricultural innovation in mitigating deforestation without constraining productivity growth.

Could Credit Save the Amazon Forest?

with Rafael Araujo, Tiago Cavalcanti, Daniel Da Mata & Fernando Chertman

Abstract. This paper investigates how rural credit shapes agricultural land use and forest conservation in Brazil. We combine farm-level evidence with a dynamic general equilibrium model of land use. We first link administrative loan records, interbank payments, and satellite imagery. Using a staggered difference-in-differences design, we find that farms in the Legal Amazon shift from pasture toward crops, increase spending on machinery and fertilizer, and retain more forest following first credit receipt, relative to farms that have not yet received credit. We then develop a dynamic model with crops, pasture, endogenous forest cover, and land rental markets which we calibrate to the Legal Amazon to evaluate how conditioning rural credit on environmental compliance affects conservation and agricultural production. In partial equilibrium, with land rents held fixed, raising borrowing costs for noncompliant farms or restricting credit to compliant farms increases long-run forest cover by 13–17%. General equilibrium adjustments reduce these gains to approximately 2%, while agricultural output remains virtually unchanged. As landowners conserve forest, the supply of cleared land falls and rents rise. Higher rents increase the income landowners forgo by retaining forest, offsetting most of the direct conservation incentive.

WORK IN PROGRESS

Hegemon, What Hegemon? The Elusive Spillovers of British and American Monetary Policies until WWII [Slides]
with Paul Bouscasse, James Cloyne & Jason Lennard

Firm Expansion, Supply Chains, and Regional Integration
with Mathis Y. Momm & Fernando Chertman

POLICY WORK

Structural Transformation, Climate and Growth: an Agricultural Extension of the Long Term Growth Model (LTGM-AG)
with Steven Pennings & Arthur Mendes

Subnational Cash Transfers in Developing Countries: A New Cross-Country Dataset
with Steven Pennings, Patricio Diaz, Yiruo Li & Arthur Mendes

PRESENTATIONS

EEA Annual Congress of the European Economic Association, Dublin (2026); AMES Asian Meeting of the Econometric Society, Hong Kong (2026); GDE-EDEG German Development Economics Conference, Kiel (2026); EAYE Annual Meeting, Bilbao (2026); RCEA Conference, Madrid (2026); LuBraMacro, Natal (2024); EAYE Annual Meeting, Paris (2024); Y-RISE Yale Research Initiative on Innovation and Scale, Grand Cayman (2023); Banco Central do Brasil, São Paulo (2023); SED Society for Economic Dynamics, Cartagena (2023); BSE Summer Forum, Barcelona (presented by co-author, 2023); CIREQ PhD Symposium (2023); University of Cambridge (2022, 2023, 2024, 2025, 2026)

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Fellow, University of Cambridge *2022 - 2023*

Macroeconomics (Undergraduate)
Econometrics Software Classes (Undergraduate and Graduate)
Dissertation Workshop (Graduate)

Lecture, FGV São Paulo *8/2024*

Spatial Data in Applied Economic Research (Graduate)

AWARDS & SCHOLARSHIPS

Keynes Fund PhD Awards *2026*

University of Cambridge

CERF PhD Scholarship *2022*

Cambridge Endowment for Research in Finance

STEG Small Research Grant *2022*

Structural Transformation and Economic Growth (STEG)

Richard Kahn Trust Award *2022/24*

Faculty of Economics Trust Fund

MSc Student Prize for best graduate at the Department of Economics *2018*

Royal Holloway, University of London

EXPERIENCE AND EMPLOYMENT

World Bank Group *2024 - 2026*

Short-Term Consultant, DECRG: Macroeconomics & Growth

University of Cambridge, Faculty of Economics *2022 - 2023*

Research Assistant for Professor Christopher Rauh

University of Oxford, Department of Economics *2019 - 2020*

Research Assistant for Professor Michael McMahon

Siemens Ltd. China, Shanghai *2014*

Internship, Department: Infrastructure & Cities

REFEREE

Ecological Economics

EXTRACURRICULAR ACTIVITIES

PhD Representative *2022 - 2023*

Faculty of Economics, University of Cambridge

Econometric Game 2023 (Team Captain) *2023*

University of Amsterdam

Social Secretary & Admiral of the Fleet *2018 - 2020*

Middle Common Room (MCR) Executive Committee
St Hilda's College, University of Oxford

LINGUISTIC PROFICIENCY

German: native speaker · English: fluent · Portuguese: basic